It was more dangerous to really strike an insoluble syllable, through impenetrable stupidity, for then there would be no end, short of absolute irreversible insanity.

I once had to demonstrate Hamlet's heartfelt cry, "What's Hecuba to him, or he to Hecuba?" and got all the short words across in short order, assuming they would all know "Hecuba" as soon as they got the rest. Unfortunately, the audience consisted of illiterate chemists and I had to get "Hecuba" across to them.

I divided it into three syllables and got the first two across so that now they had, "What's Hecu— to him, or he to Hecu —" and there it stuck. Nothing I could do could get across a "buh," although I would have sworn a child of three who had never heard any language but Montenegrin would have known the entire phrase by then. Finally, I screamed incoherently and left the room. I wasn't really mad. I came back after a few hours.

My sharpest memory, though, is trying to get the word "one" across to a particular person. I held up my forefinger confidently and she said, "First word!" as a matter of course, because that is the recognized sign for the first word of a phrase. I shook my head vigorously, and held up first the forefinger, then the middle finger, too, and finally the ring finger as well, indicating each stage in exaggerated fashion, and she said, "One, two, three." I nodded with fatuous glee and held up one finger, signifying the first of these three words, and she said, "First word."

My eyes grew bloodshot. I went through the same ritual. She said, "One, two, three," at which I pointed to the first finger and slowly curled down the other two. She said, "First word."

I was jumping up and down in frenzy, unable to get out of the routine I had chosen for myself. I indicated one finger, two fingers, three fingers, then shook the first finger under her nose; I did it over and over and over, and finally left the finger there while performing an entrechat and split to emphasize it completely.

Finally, a look of dawning comprehension permeated her entire being and she said, "Finger!!!!!"

I don't know what happened after that. Everything went black and the next thing I knew it was morning.